

NENU (Me / I)

A Short Film Screenplay

(Telugu dialogues written entirely in English script — natural, everyday spoken Telugu)

CHARACTERS:

Raghu — Father, 50s

Lakshmi — Mother, 40s

Ramya — Elder daughter, 24

Swathi — Younger daughter, 19

Divya — Swathi's close friend, 19

Padma Pinni — Relative/matchmaker who brings the marriage proposal

SCENE 1 — INT. HOUSE, LIVING ROOM — DAY (FLASHBACK, WARM TONE)

Family photos on the wall. SWATHI (14) and RAMYA (19) are laughing, chasing each other around the sofa. LAKSHMI is scolding them playfully while cooking. RAGHU sits reading a newspaper, smiling without looking up.

SWATHI: *(giggling)* Akka, thappinchukoku, ippudu pattukuntanu ninnu!

RAMYA: *(running)* Pattukolevu le, try chey!

LAKSHMI: *(shouting from kitchen)* Ay, iddaru aagandi, illu padagotestharu ala!

RAGHU: *(not lifting his eyes from paper, smiling)* Vadileyi Lakshmi... pillalu kada, aadukoni.

(He looks up, watches them play, deep contentment on his face. No narration — just the moment.)

SCENE 2 — INT. HOUSE, DINING TABLE — NIGHT

Family eating together. RAGHU, at ease, talking to his FRIEND on a phone call, on speaker.

RAGHU: *(on phone, proud, warming up to his favorite topic)* Ledu ra baa, maa pillala vishayamlo nenu chala different ra. Chinnapati nunchi vaalliki nenu eppudu "idi cheyaku, adi cheyaku" ani cheppaledu. Full ga freedom icchanu, respect icchanu. Chudu, ala perigina pillalu eppudu thappu dari pattaru ra, idi naa guarantee kuda.

(Lakshmi smiles at him from across the table. Ramya and Swathi exchange a quiet look — Ramya's smile falters for a second, unnoticed.)

SCENE 3 — INT. HOUSE, SWATHI'S ROOM — NIGHT (TIME SKIP — YEARS LATER)

SWATHI (19 now) is asleep. Her phone buzzes. A message from RAMYA: "Nenu vellipothunnanu Swathi... nannu kshaminchu."

Swathi sits up, confused, dials Ramya's number. No answer. She runs out of the room.

SWATHI: *(panicked, shouting)* Amma! Amma, akka phone teeyatledu!

SCENE 4 — INT. HOUSE, LIVING ROOM — DAY

Chaos. Relatives gathered. Everyone whispering. LAKSHMI is crying silently in a corner. RAGHU sits like a stone, staring at nothing.

RELATIVE 1: *(whispering, but loud enough)* Choosara, entha ga freedom icharo papalaki... ippudu chudu, em ayyindo!

RELATIVE 2: Raghu gaaru inka moham ela pettukuntaro bayataki, evariki cheppukoledu ippudu.

(Raghu's jaw tightens. He hears every word. Swathi stands at the doorway, watching her father's face crumble in real time.)

SCENE 5 — INT. HOUSE, RAGHU'S ROOM — NIGHT

Raghu sits alone in the dark. Lakshmi enters quietly, sits beside him.

LAKSHMI: *(softly)* Enduku ila kurchunnaru... randi annam thineddam.

RAGHU: *(voice breaking)* Nenu em thappu chesano ardham kavatledu Lakshmi.

LAKSHMI: Ey... vinandi naa maata konchem.

RAGHU: *(cutting her off, staring ahead)* Swathi inka undi. Ika thanni ila vadileyalenu. Inkosari ee inti paruvu pokudadu.

(A long, heavy silence. This is the moment his fear turns into control.)

SCENE 6 — INT. HOUSE, SWATHI'S ROOM — DAY (MONTAGE, TIME SKIP)

A series of quick moments, no dialogue narration — just action and short lines —

— *Swathi's phone is taken away by Raghu without a word.*

— *Swathi is stopped at the door, going to meet friends.*

RAGHU: *(flat)* Ekkadiki?

— *Report card scene: Raghu stares at it, silent, disappointed. Swathi stands, head down.*

RAGHU: *(cold)* Marks thaggayi. Ekkada untunnavu roju antha?

SWATHI: *(quiet)* Nanna, nenu chadive chadivanu...

RAGHU: *(interrupting)* Saripoledu. Ninnu nammi vadileste idi jarugutundi ippudu.

(Swathi's eyes well up but she says nothing. She walks away.)

SCENE 7 — EXT. COLLEGE GATE — DAY

Swathi waits near the gate. DIVYA, her closest friend, walks up — but stops a few feet away instead of hugging her like usual. Awkward distance.

SWATHI: *(smiling, hopeful)* Divya! Chala rojulaindi kada manam kalisi... ee roju evening ki maa intiki veldhama?

DIVYA: *(not meeting her eyes)* Swathi... naaku ee roju kudaradu anukunta. Assignment undi konchem.

SWATHI: *(gentle, sensing something)* Divya, em ayindi? Nenu em thappu chesana?

DIVYA: *(hesitating, then quietly)* Nee thappu kadu Swathi... maa amma cheppindi, "vaalla intlo problems unnayi, konchem dooram ga undu" ani. Naaku em cheppalo ardham kavatledu.

(Swathi's face falls — this hurts more than anything her parents have said.)

SWATHI: *(quiet, stunned, taking a moment to process)* ...Nijamena? Mee amma ala annara...? *(a pause, voice shaking)* Naaku telusu intlo jarigindi thappu ani, kani... nenu maatram maaraledu kada Divya.

DIVYA: *(guilty, backing away)* Naaku telusu... kani nenu em cheyagalanu ippudu. Sorry ra Swathi.

(Divya walks away. Swathi stands alone at the gate, watching her only real friendship disappear too.)

SCENE 8 — INT. HOUSE, KITCHEN DOORWAY — NIGHT

Swathi walks toward the kitchen for water, stops when she hears her parents' hushed voices with PADMA PINNI on speakerphone. She stays hidden at the doorway.

PADMA PINNI: *(on phone, brisk)* Raghu gaaru, Swathi ki manchi sambandham okati vachindi. Software engineer, Hyderabad lo settled. Vaallu ventane chudali anukuntunnaru.

RAGHU: *(low, tired)* Pinni gaaru, thanu inka chinnade kada... chaduvu kuda avvaledu inka.

PADMA PINNI: Raghu gaaru, ippudu marketlo manchi sambandhalu dorakadam kastam. Okasari edaina jarigithe... meeku telusuga ilanti vi tvaraga jaragadame manchidi.

(A long silence. Lakshmi looks at Raghu, worried. Raghu rubs his face, not saying no.)

RAGHU: *(quietly, almost to himself)* Sare... okasari chuddam.

(Swathi steps back from the doorway slowly, her water forgotten, her stomach in knots. She wasn't supposed to hear this — but now she can't unhear it.)

SCENE 9 — INT. HOUSE, KITCHEN — DAY

Swathi sits at the table, not eating. Lakshmi notices.

LAKSHMI: *(gently, sitting beside her)* Swathi, enduku ala unnavu... tinatledu kuda ivvala?

SWATHI: *(barely audible)* Amma... nenu chala tired ga feel avuthunnanu. Chaduvu meeda concentrate cheyalekapothunnanu. Nenu happy ga ledi amma.

LAKSHMI: *(worried, holding her hand)* Cheppu naatho, em ayyindi? Chala rojula nunchi chustunnanu nuvvu correct ga ledi ani.

SWATHI: *(voice cracking)* Naa thappu em ledi amma. Akka chesindi thappu, kani punishment nenu theesukuntunnanu. Prathi roju nannu suspect chestunnaru. Nenu breathe kuda saripoyinatlu theesukolekapothunnanu ee intlo.

(Lakshmi's eyes fill with tears. She pulls Swathi into a hug. RAGHU enters, overhears the last part, standing frozen at the door.)

SCENE 10 — INT. HOUSE, LIVING ROOM — NIGHT

The house phone rings. LAKSHMI answers, casual — then her face changes completely.

LAKSHMI: *(soft, shaken)* ...Ramya?

(Raghu, reading nearby, goes rigid. Swathi appears at the hallway, frozen, listening.)

LAKSHMI: *(into phone, voice trembling)* Nuvvu bagunnava thalli? Tinnava emaina...

(Raghu stands abruptly, walks to Lakshmi, silently holds his hand out for the phone. Lakshmi hesitates, then gives it to him. A long pause. He doesn't speak. He simply hangs up. No anger, no words — just a wall coming down.)

LAKSHMI: *(quietly, tears falling)* Vinandi... thanu maa papa. Enta jariginaa...

RAGHU: *(hollow)* Naaku telusu thanu evaaro Lakshmi. Kani ippudu nenu maatladalenu thanato. Inka kadu.

(He walks away. Swathi, still in the hallway, quietly wipes her own tears — caught between missing her sister and being terrified of becoming her.)

SCENE 11 — INT. HOUSE, LIVING ROOM — DAY (LATER)

Raghu confronts Swathi, trying to mask his own fear with anger.

RAGHU: *(sharp, almost mocking)* Enti ee gola anta? "Depressed" ta, "motivation ledu" ta... marks thakkuva vachaayi ani ivanni cheppadam chala easy kada neeku!

SWATHI: *(hurt, trying to explain)* Nanna, nijamgane nenu try chestunnanu... kani naaku enduko oka pani meeda concentration ravatledu.

RAGHU: *(cutting her off, harsh)* Naaku ivanni vinali anipinchatledu ippudu. Velli chaduvuko, inka em cheppaku.

(He walks away. Swathi stands there, shattered — this is the moment something inside her breaks completely.)

SCENE 12 — INT. HOUSE, LIVING ROOM — DAY

The rishtha visit. The groom's family sits stiffly on the sofa. Swathi is brought out, dressed up, made to serve coffee — a performance. Their eyes assess her like an item.

GROOM'S MOTHER: *(inspecting)* Bagunnadi paapa. *(to Lakshmi)* Kitchen work anni vastundaa thanaki?

LAKSHMI: *(nervous smile)* Avunu avunu, anni vastayi...

GROOM'S MOTHER: *(to Swathi directly, testing)* Nuvvu job cheyaali anukuntunnava, ledha intlo undaali anukuntunnava?

(Swathi glances at her father, who avoids her eyes — waiting for her to just answer correctly and get through it. Something in her finally refuses to perform.)

SWATHI: *(quiet but steady)* Naaku inka em kavalo naake ardham kavatledu aunty gaaru... enduku ante chala rojula nunchi naa ishtam evaru adagaledu.

(Silence. The groom's mother's smile stiffens. Raghu's face goes pale — the room feels the weight of what Swathi just said in front of strangers.)

RAGHU: *(quickly, covering)* Sare sare, thanu konchem tired ga undi ee roju...

(He forces a laugh. But Swathi has already gotten up and walked toward her room, leaving the guests stunned. This is the breaking point.)

SCENE 13 — INT. HOUSE, SWATHI'S ROOM — NIGHT

Swathi sits on the floor, back against the bed, crying hard — the kind of crying that's been building for months. Old photos scattered around her — childhood pictures of her and Ramya playing.

SWATHI: *(sobbing, to herself)* Aa rojulu entha bagundi ra... evaru adagaru, evaru anumanincheledu... nenu eppudu ila ayipoyanu?

(Lakshmi hears her from outside, opens the door slowly. Sees her daughter broken on the floor. She rushes in, sits beside her, holds her tightly. Raghu appears at the door, watching silently.)

LAKSHMI: *(crying too)* Swathi, amma ikkade undi thalli...

SWATHI: *(through sobs, looking up, seeing her father too)* Nanna... nenu akka la kaadu. Naa friends ni pogottukunnu, naa peace ni pogottukunnu, meetho happy ga undali ani prathi roju try chesanu... kani meeku ippatiki nenante nammakam ledu. Akka chesindi thappu ani naaku telusu, nenu aa vishayamlo thanni support cheyanu. Kani nenu akka la unte, ee intlo inni rojulu aagedaanni kadu nanna... eppudo vellipoyedaanni.

(She breaks down completely. Silence. Raghu's face changes — the words hit him harder than anything has since Ramya left.)

SCENE 14 — VOICE-OVER — QUICK VISUAL MONTAGE (THE ONLY V.O. IN THE FILM)

Screen holds on Raghu and Swathi's faces, frozen in the moment. Quick, silent flashback flashes play — each just a second or two — while we hear their voices, not talking to each other, but each speaking their own truth for the first time.

SWATHI (V.O.): *(quiet, raw)* Nenu prove chesukovali anukoledu meeku nenu manchi daanni ani. Nenu kevalam inkosari free ga oopiri theesukovali anukunnu, anthe.

(Flash: young Swathi laughing freely in Scene 1.)

RAGHU (V.O.): *(low, guilty)* Nenu ninnu kolpothanemo ane bhayamtho ninnu inka gattiga pattukovali anukunnu. Kani adi pattukovadam kaadu... adi oopiri aapadam ani naaku ardham kaledu.

(Flash: Raghu's proud phone call in Scene 2.)

SWATHI (V.O.): Nenu akka kaadu nanna. Nenu meeku prathi roju prove chesukovali ani bathikanu... adi kuda thappe ayindi.

(The flashes fade. We return to the present — Raghu and Swathi, still looking at each other, silence between them heavier than before.)

SCENE 15 — INT. HOUSE, SWATHI'S ROOM — CONTINUOUS

Raghu slowly walks in, sits on the floor in front of his daughter for the first time as an equal, not as an authority.

RAGHU: *(voice shaking, almost a whisper)* Swathi... nannu kshaminchu.

(He wipes his eyes.)

RAGHU: Akka vellipoyinappudu, nenu ninnu kuda kolpothanemo ani bhayapaddanu. Aa bhayamlo ninnu akka lane chudatam modalu pettanu. Nee meeda kaadu Swathi... naa bhayam meeda nenu kopam chupinchanu.

LAKSHMI: *(softly, to Raghu)* Naaku kuda inni rojulu em cheppalekapoyanu... manam iddaram kalisi thanni ila baadha pettamu.

(All three are crying now. A long beat of silence, just breathing and tears.)

RAGHU: *(holding her, voice thick)* Nuvvu em chesina, ekkada unna... nenu ninnu nammuthanu. Nee ishtam vachinatlu bathuku thalli. Aa sambandham, chaduvu, friends... anni nee ishtam. Nee meeda naaku nammakam undi... eppatiki untundi.

(Swathi clutches him tighter, finally letting go of everything she's been holding. Lakshmi wraps her arms around both of them.)

SWATHI: *(muffled, crying into his shoulder)* Nanna...

(No more words needed. The three of them stay like that — broken, but together again.)

SCENE 16 — INT. HOUSE, LIVING ROOM — DAY (EPILOGUE, WEEKS LATER)

Swathi is at the door, dressed to go meet her friends. She looks back, almost out of habit, expecting to be stopped.

Raghu looks up from his newspaper — just like Scene 1 — and smiles.

RAGHU: *(warm, easy)* Time ki ra intiki, jagratha ga vellira.

(Swathi smiles — a real, free smile — for the first time in the film. She walks out. Raghu watches her go, and this time, there's no fear in his eyes. Only trust.)

FADE OUT.

END